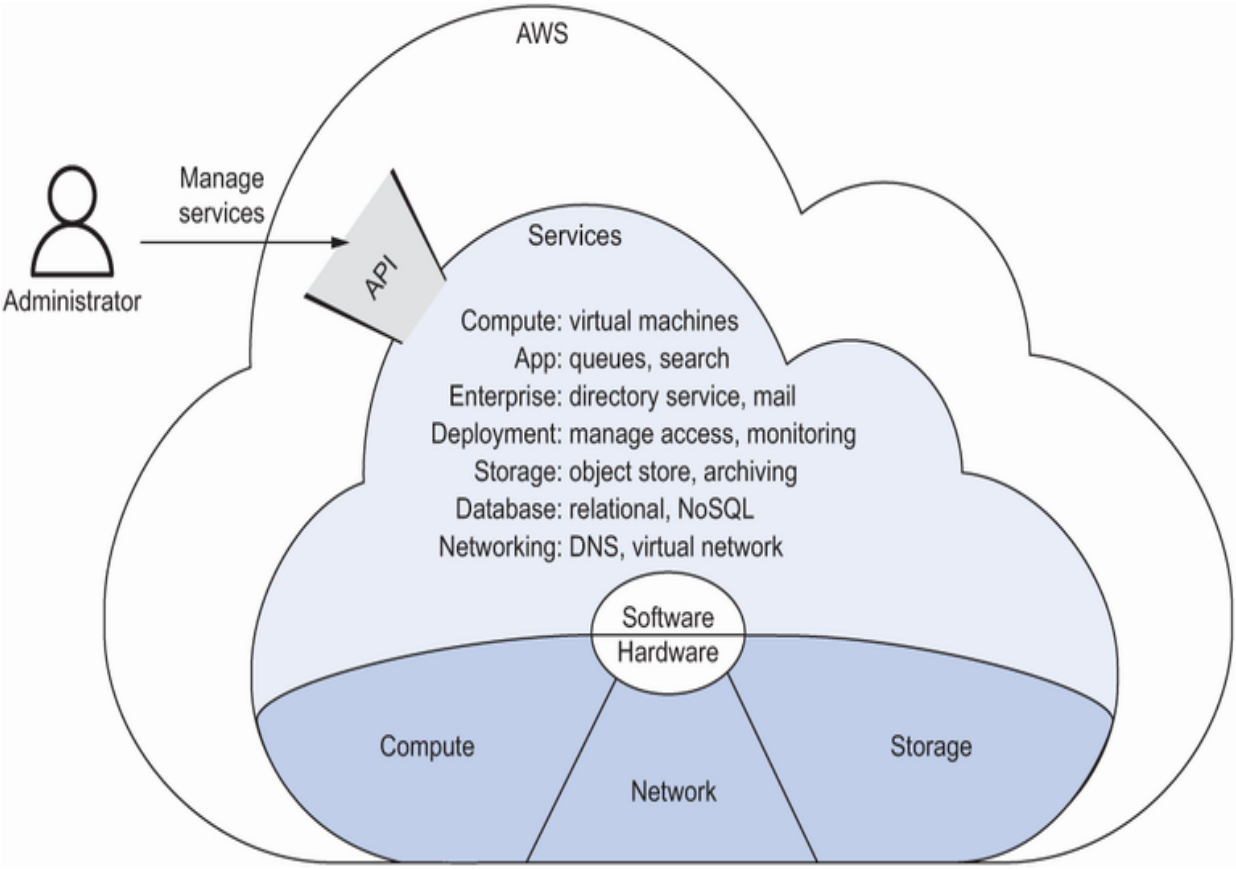


Figure 1.9 The AWS cloud is composed of hardware and software services accessible via an API.

You can manage services by sending requests to the API manually via a web-based GUI like the Management Console, a command-line interface (CLI), or programmatically via an SDK. Virtual machines have a special feature: you can connect to virtual machines through SSH, for example, and gain administrator access. This means you can install any software you like on a virtual machine. Other services, like the NoSQL database service, offer their features through an API and hide everything that's going on behind the scenes. Figure 1.10 shows an administrator installing a custom PHP web application on a virtual machine and managing dependent services such as a NoSQL database used by the application.